

1392

JOSEON DYNASTY RULES KOREA

In 1388, Korean general Yi Seong-gye was ordered by Korea's ruler, King U of Goryeo, to invade Ming China. Sure that attacking the Ming would lead to military disaster, Yi instead turned his troops against the king and took control of the government. Four years later, Yi declared himself King Taejo, establishing a new dynasty, the Joseon, that would rule Korea for over 500 years.



△ Joseon lacquer box

▽ The Battle of Grunwald, Jan Matejko



1390

1396 At the Battle of Nicopolis, European knights are massacred by Ottoman forces

1402 Zhu Di becomes the Yongle Emperor in China: he is considered the second founder of the Ming dynasty

1408 The Yongle Encyclopedia, commissioned by the Ming emperor, is completed: it has 11,095 volumes

Zheng He's first treasure fleet in 1405 was crewed by 27,800 men on 317 ships

1405

VOYAGES OF ZHENG HE

In 1403, China's Yongle Emperor ordered the construction of a fleet, aiming to demonstrate China's superiority in Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean. Commanded by the eunuch Zheng He, this "treasure fleet" made seven epic voyages between 1405 and 1432, travelling as far as Sri Lanka and East Africa and collecting treasures including live animals.

▷ A giraffe collected by the treasure fleet

